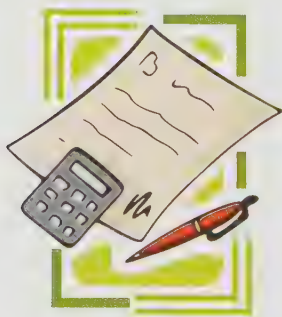


estimating as you go along. You'll also get better at knowing what you need. A friend might only need to spend \$50 a month on gas, but your visits to Grandma Sue push that up to \$100 for you. It's okay.

Also, part of what a budget is intended to do is to track money *over time*. So if your cell bill is high one month, it might be lower the next. Maybe you'll change plans in six months and pay a lower monthly fee. Your budget will show you your average spending, which will both cancel out some extra costs you might pay along the way and help you make a better average next time.

## 2. Budget for yourself

You have needs and desires that others don't have. I, for instance, really want to take a pottery class next fall. So right now I'm starting to budget for it. It shouldn't be too expensive, but I want to be sure those recreational costs are covered. These are costs that others



won't have, but they're important to me and that's okay.

Many budget programs come with a list of categories, and it's easy to feel like you need to fit your spending into those. Instead, wipe the memory clean of categories and start from the beginning. Make *your* budget reflect *your* life, or it won't help *you* save. It might help Joe Generic save, or the couple two doors down, but it won't help you.

## 3. It's okay to overspend sometimes

Money isn't the highest priority. When something else is more important than keeping to your budget or saving money, and you make the decision, it's okay to overspend. For Valentine's Day, my husband and I went out to dinner. It wasn't anything particularly fancy, but it cost us a little extra in our "eating out" category.

For us, that was okay because we decided to overspend. We were intentional about it and evaluated it in light of the other categories in the budget. Since we didn't spend nearly our full amount in other categories, and we really needed a break, we decided to splurge a little. It's hard to see the numbers at the bottom of our column turn red (that means we overspent) and not feel like I'm somehow